



experimental, the Dutch and the Germans still landed with 11 and nine members respectively from their Olympic sides, which makes India's performances all the more laudable.

Harendra has always insisted on fitness being the backbone of all strategies and their executions, and the team, when playing to its strengths and sticking to its plans, proved capable of matching up to the higher-ranked sides. Deepika continues to go from strength to strength, both as a striker and the team's main drag-flicker. The

newcomers — Sakshi Rana, Rutuja Pisal and Jyoti Singh — all impressed, and with more, including the likes of Kanika Siwach and Deepika Soreng, waiting in the wings, the team appears to be on the right track.

The biggest concern, however, will be to ensure a replacement is in place well in time for Savita Punia. Although Bichu Devi was competent in the chances she got, there is no denying that Savita remains key to India's fortunes, and by the time she calls it a day, one hopes Indian women's hockey has her successor

Central figure: There is no denying that Savita remains key to Indian's fortunes. THE HOCKEY INDIA

ready.

The big caveat, though, remains that the Pro League continues to be a testing ground for all teams, both in planning and personnel, before more important tournaments, with its results valued accordingly.

But if the first half of the current season is any indication, Indian hockey seems prepared for the tough days ahead.